

▲ SHYAMKUMAR BARVE, *46*

| CONGRESS | *Ramtek (SC), Maharashtra*

It was former Nagpur zilla parishad chief Rashmi Barve who was to be the Congress candidate from Ramtek, a seat reserved for SCs. But it was her husband Shyamkumar who ended up fighting the election in her place since Rashmi's caste certificate was cancelled. The Barves are supporters of ex-Congress minister Sunil Kedar. Shyamkumar himself is a coal miner's son, and was deputy sarpanch of Kandri village. Shyamkumar got the better of Congress MLA Raju Parwe, who had switched to the Shiv Sena for a Lok Sabha nomination.



▲ ASHISH DUBEY, *54*

| BJP | *Jabalpur, MP*

When the BJP announced Ashish Dubey as the candidate from the Jabalpur LS seat, the general reaction was that a deserving worker has been rewarded. Dubey hails from a family of landowners from the Katangi-Patan area in rural Jabalpur. He has held various organisational posts in the BJP and is presently its state general secretary. Dubey's name was doing the rounds for an assembly segment in Jabalpur before the 2023 assembly polls too. He beat the Congress's Dinesh Yadav by over 480,000 votes. Armed with BCom and law degrees, Dubey vows to work for the development of his constituency.

▶ VIJAYLAKSHMI DEVI, *61*

| JD(U) | *Siwan, Bihar*



In a landscape still in the long shadow of its ex-MP Mohammed Shahabuddin, you'd think challenging his widow, Hina Sahab, contesting as an Independent, was a lost cause. But Vijaylakshmi Devi, exemplar of Nitish Kumar's Luv-Kush (Kurmi-Kushwaha) equation, conquered all misgiving—and her rival-in-chief. Vijaylaksmi's political leanings have mirrored her husband's, the former JD(U) MLA Ramesh Singh Kushwaha, who has been with the CPI(ML) Liberation, the JD(U), the Rashtriya Lok Samata Party, and back to the JD(U) in March.



ANI

◀ BIJULI KALITA MEDHI, *45*

| BJP | *Guwahati, Assam*

Medhi started her career as a grassroots BJP worker with no political legacy, and was a surprise pick by the party—which dropped its sitting MP, Queen Ojha—for the prestigious Guwahati constituency. A post-graduate from Guwahati University, she is a former president of the BJP's Mahila Morcha and a vice-president of the party's Assam unit. Medhi defeated firebrand Mira Borthakur Goswami, who had defected from the BJP to the Congress in 2018, by a margin of 251,090 votes.

▶ KALICHARAN SINGH, *62*

| BJP | *Chatra, Jharkhand*



Kalicharan's career trajectory has followed the exact path of state BJP president Babulal Marandi, whose close associate he is. Like Marandi, Kalicharan began as a teacher. The son of a school headmaster himself, he taught mathematics in a government school. Like Marandi, he too quit his job to become a full-time BJP worker. That was in 1986, and Kalicharan rose steadily through the ranks to become the state BJP vice president. Remarkably, the 2024 Lok Sabha polls was the first time he contested any election. Kalicharan was fielded in place of sitting MP Sunil Kumar Singh and did not disappoint, felling his rival, the Congress's Krishna Nand Tripathi, by a handsome 220,000-vote margin.

-Ajay Sukumaran, Amitabh Srivastava, Prashant Srivastava, Dhaval S. Kulkarni, Rahul Noronha, Rohit Parihar and Arkamoy Datta Majumdar